Chapter 19

The Scenario Changeth:
Setting New Standards

FOR PURPOSES OF SECURITY AND SUPERVISION, TIHAR HAD A FORCE OF 1500 officers and jawans. Their welfare, too, was part and parcel of jail administration.

'In an effort to bring about changes in the living conditions of prisoners,' pointed out Deputy Superintendent Bhupinder Singh Jarial, 'a lot had also been demanded of the jail staff. They certainly put in a lot of extra effort and that too with a marked change in their attitude. Their welfare was therefore equally important. This job required total devotion. Plus there was no time limit. At times one may have to put in so many extra hours. It did put a strain on social and family commitments.'

A number of activities were introduced for ensuring staff welfare. An institute was opened for lady members of staff families, such as their wives and daughters, where they were taught skills like sewing, tailoring, cutting and so on. This step was taken so that family income could be enhanced. The owner of Filterex India, Gulshan Sikri, launched a training programme for staff families for the manufacture of filters for the automobile industry. During training each member earned Rs 30 per day. After that a regular income of Rs 1000–2000 per month was assured. Duty hours of the staff members were also staggered so that they could spend more time with their families.

Regarding the staff salaries, the deputy superintendent clarified: 'The Third Pay Commission had held the jail staff salaries, especially of those of the lower ranks, at par with the Delhi Police. But the Fourth PC left us behind as we were not represented there. The matter had been taken to court and our claims were declared to be justified. As a matter of fact, the chief minister of Delhi announced that these will be brought into effect immediately and that release of arrears will be expedited.'

As the prisoners responded to the invigorating winds of change blowing through Tihar, they commenced placing requests orally as well as through the petition system for physical education and yoga classes. The response to such legitimate requests was immediate.

TV personality and yoga instructor Sardari Lal Sehgal was contacted and he agreed at once to the request for holding yoga classes in the jail. The inmates had already seen him conduct such classes on TV sets in their barracks and he certainly needed no introduction.

'In June 1993, when yoga classes were started there were just half a dozen participants,' recalled Sardari Lal Sehgal, 'but within a month about 90 inmates started turning up regularly. The younger ones took it up more enthusiastically.'

Soon, two more yoga instructors were inducted from outside and according to the superintendent of Jail 4: 'By year [1993] end there were 250 prisoners undertaking these classes daily. And this figure was just for Jail 4.'

The chief minister of Delhi, Madan Lal Khurana, visited Tihar on 18 December 1993. He was duly impressed by the efforts of the IG (Prisons) and the effective changes she had brought about in the